names of God or verses from the Quran are repeated, ‘perfumes are burnt and sweetmeats are distributed’ – possibly the Sufi meditational practice called *zikr*.[12]

Once before, on Akbar’s return from his riverine conquest of Bengal, Badauni described him absorbed in such meditation, on a rock outside his palace in Fatehpur. Then, perhaps, Akbar was looking for a ‘true’ path, one God from all the multitudes of faiths around him in whom to believe. Almost thirty years later, why would the emperor return to the customs of his youth – the devotions that, according to Badauni, he had long abandoned?

Akbar’s successes had made him proverbial while he lived. ‘Scarcely ever did he engage in an enterprise which he did not bring to a successful conclusion’, wrote a Jesuit, ‘so that “as fortunate as Echebar” became a common saying throughout the East.’[13] The emperor would have been quite sure of God’s help against the rock-solid walls of Asirgarh, or against Ahmednagar and Chand Bibi. In fact, as the siege dragged on without success, Akbar had taken to repeating a comforting prophecy: ‘This fort will be taken.’[14]

Abul Fazl sounds less impressed with the mantra than he might once have been. In fact, in a startling detour from his usual faith in the emperor’s divine destiny, Abul Fazl comes close to suggesting that the Mughal army’s slow progress against Asirgarh was partly Akbar’s fault. It was this prophecy of his that was making the men lazy as ‘many accepting the soothing words continued to slumber’.

Not so the writer.

In November 1600, eight months after escorting Akbar to Burhanpur, Abul Fazl set out on a ‘dark and rainy night’ to scale one of Asirgarh’s many battlements. So far, the Mughal forces had managed no assault on the fortress, no breach of its walls; their only success had been to occupy a neighbouring hill, which offered a better view and line of fire to Asirgarh. Abul Fazl, however, had learnt of a secret path up the hill, to the fort walls. Few in the army were as enthused as the writer by the prospect of a midnight scouting expedition into heavily guarded enemy terrain. ‘However much I tried the men would not give their minds to the subject,’ Abul Fazl complains. They had reason for their reluctance. Another contemporary